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Salammatt Husain/Gulf News

THOUSANDS FLOCK TO DUBAI FOUNTAIN'S FINAL SHOWS

It was a sea of spectators at The Dubai Mall Waterfront Promenade on Saturday evening as thousands of residents and tourists gathered to witness the final performances of the iconic Dubai Fountain before it goes silent for a five-month renovation project. The world-renowned fountain, launched in 2009, delivered a breathtaking series of final shows, drawing emotions, applause, and a sense of nostalgia from some of the spectators.

SEE ALSO P3

UAE's foreign trade hit Dh5.23tr in 2024

NATION ACCOUNTS FOR 41% OF MIDDLE EAST'S EXPORTS

DUBAI
Gulf News Report

His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, has announced that the UAE's foreign trade volume reached Dh5.23 trillion in 2024, with a trade surplus exceeding Dh490 billion.

On his official X account, Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid also revealed that in 2024, the UAE exported services worth Dh650 billion, including Dh191 billion in digital services, which accounted for 30 per cent of total service exports.

Citing the latest data from the World Trade Organisation, Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid added that the UAE exported goods worth Dh2.2 trillion in 2024, representing a 6 per cent

Dh650b
worth of services
exported, Dh191b
in digital services

increase over the previous year. The UAE now accounts for 41 per cent of the Middle East's total merchandise exports, reaffirming its position as the region's leading trading hub.

"In a world facing major economic and commercial challenges, the UAE chose, from the very beginning, a path of openness — building bridges, and enabling the free movement of trade, capital, and people," Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid wrote. "Today, the UAE stands out as a vital bridge between East and West, and a dynamic global economic hub," he added.

"By the grace of Allah, this journey of progress will continue. Under the leadership of the UAE President, we will preserve these achievements and continue to build upon them."

Leadership hailed

In his reply on the X platform, President His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Zayed Al Nahyan praised Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid's leadership, stating: "You have never let us down, my brother Bu Rashid. With your vision, and the dedication of determined, sincere, and capable Emirati teams, you continue to demonstrate to the world that the UAE is truly an exceptional country — just as the late Shaikh Zayed, the nation's founding father, envisioned. Thank you, Shaikh Mohammad, and thank you to all our Emirati sons and daughters who are devoted to the progress and prosperity of our nation."

Pettit, Nasa's oldest active astronaut, back on Earth

He celebrated 70th birthday on way back

WASHINGTON

Cake, gifts and a low-key family celebration may be how many senior citizens picture their 70th birthday.

But Nasa's oldest serving astronaut Don Pettit became a septuagenarian while hurtling towards the Earth in a spacecraft to wrap up a seven-month mission aboard the International Space Station (ISS).

A Soyuz capsule carrying the American and two Russian cosmonauts landed in Kazakhstan yesterday, the day of Pettit's milestone

birthday. Spending 220 days in space, Pettit and his crewmates Alexei Ovchinin and Ivan Vagner orbited the Earth 3,520 times and completed a journey of 93.3 million miles over the course of their mission.

It was the fourth spaceflight for Pettit, who has logged more than 18 months in orbit during his 29-year career. The trio touched down in southeast of Dzhezkazgan in Kazakhstan at 0120 GMT after undocking from the space station just over three hours earlier.

— AFP

Self-driving taxis to launch soon in Dubai

First phase of trials with 50 autonomous vehicles; full-scale operations from 2026

DUBAI
BY ASHWANI KUMAR
Chief Reporter

In a pivotal step towards the realisation of Dubai's Smart Self-Driving Transport Strategy, Dubai's Roads and Transport Authority (RTA) has signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with Baidu's autonomous ride-hailing service, Apollo Go, to roll out autonomous taxis on a large scale across the emirate.

The strategy aims to convert 25 per cent of all trips in Dubai into autonomous journeys across various modes of transport by 2030.

Under the terms of the MoU, Apollo Go will begin the experimental operation of 50 autonomous vehicles in the coming months, paving the way for the official public launch of the service in 2026.

40 sensors and detectors

It will deploy the latest generation of its autonomous taxis RT6, specifically designed for autonomous mobility services. These vehicles are equipped with 40 sensors and detectors to ensure



the highest standards of automation and safety. This model has already achieved remarkable success and garnered widespread acclaim from users in China.

The data collection and testing phase will commence with 50 vehicles in the coming months, gradually expanding to 1,000 autonomous taxis over the next three years, according to the established efficiency and service quality standards. This launch marks Apollo Go's first international expansion in the testing and operation of autonomous vehicles outside China mainland and Hong Kong.

To date, the company has logged over 150 million kilometres of safe driving, enabling large-scale self-driving taxi services across multiple cities in China, in addition to the roll out of 100 per cent driverless operations. It has also completed more than 10 million autonomous trips, making it the world's largest operator of autonomous vehicle fleets.

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